jailed and since FICCI passed a resolution withholding its cooperation unless the Conference was attended by Gandhi, or had his approval, Purshotamdas did not attend the first meeting of the Round Table Conference.[2] In January 1931, Congress leaders were unconditionally released and shortly afterwards Gandhi's negotiations culminated in the famous Gandhi–Irwin Pact. Irwin retired in April and was succeeded by Lord Willingdon. Though some differences cropped up between the new Viceroy and Gandhi on the interpretation of the Pact, these were smoothed out and Gandhi sailed for London in August 1931 as the sole representative of the Congress. On conclusion of the Gandhi–Irwin Pact, the Federation had decided that it would be represented by three persons. Along with Purshotamdas, G.D. Birla and Jamal Mohamed were nominated to represent the Federation at the Second Round Table Conference which was held in London from September 1931.

The Second Round Table Conference

Some of the subjects which figured prominently in the discussions included the question of financial safeguards, commercial discrimination, the status of the rupee following the British government's decision to go off the gold standard, and proposals for the establishment of the RBI. Purshotamdas was naturally more interested in the economic aspects but such was the respect he commanded that his assistance was sought even in political matters by the Mahatma and other members. While he had no party affiliations, his ability, undoubted patriotism, and intellectual integrity were greatly admired by both his friends and adversaries and induced men of varied political affiliations to take him into confidence. His work in the Legislature had earned him universal admiration and many political parties had tried to woo him, but in vain. Purshotamdas's temperament was ill-suited to the strait-jacket of party politics. His independent nature was more suited to taking up cudgels on behalf of a worthy national cause than toeing a party line calculated to merely further party interests.

Purshotamdas and Gandhi shared a relationship of mutual respect.[3] Both belonged to the same caste and Purshotamdas's wife was related to Gandhi. Their association extended over several decades and Gandhi had judged Purshotamdas more accurately than perhaps any other Indian leader. Not